What you need to know about: **Foundations of Historical Thinking**

THE BIG PICTURE

Our understanding of the past changes with new evidence, with shifting cultural values, and with changes in who holds the power to tell the story.

Key Concept	Related Concepts	Global Context:
Change	Causality, Perspective, Power	Personal and cultural expression

Lenses of Historical Thinking

Political	Who held power, and how did they use it?
Social	How did this affect everyday people?
Economic	Who gained, and who lost?
Cultural	How did this change what people believed or valued?
Technological	What did new technology make possible?
Environmental	How did nature shape events, and how did events change nature?

Historical Thinking Concepts

Change	How things became different over time.
Continuity	What stayed the same, even while other things changed.
Cause	The reasons an event happened.
Consequence	The results of an event, both intended and unintended.
Significance	Why an event matters: who it affected, how deeply, for how long.
Perspectives	How/why people, and historians later, saw an event differently

Types of disputes, and the questions they ask

Factual	Disagreement about what actually happened.	What happened?
Causal	Facts agreed on; dispute is why it happened.	Why did it happen?
Value	Facts agreed on; dispute is how the event should be judged (justified, harmful, heroic, criminal).	Was it right or wrong?
Significance	How important the event was.	How much did it matter?

The Historian's Toolkit

Primary source	Evidence created at the time by people who experienced the event (letters, diaries, photos, official records).
Secondary source	An account created later by someone who did not experience the event, usually built from primary sources.
Archive	A collection where original records are kept. Who controls an archive controls what historians can see.
Oral history	Recorded interviews with people who lived through events. Often the only record of voices left out of official documents.
Corroboration	Checking a source against other sources to see if they agree.
OPVL	Evaluating a source by its Origin, Purpose, Value and Limitations.
Selection and framing	Each account involves choices: where the story begins and ends; what is included and what is left out; whose voices are heard.

Why interpretations change

New evidence	New sources are found/analyzed, which changes what can be known.
Shifting values	Society's values change, which changes the questions historians ask.
Power	A change in who holds power changes who gets to tell the story.

Explaining causes

Conditions	Long-term factors that made an event possible.
Decisions	Specific choices by specific people that made an event happen.

When analyzing, ask…	Source	Interpretation	Dispute
	Who/when/where/why	What's the claim?	What changed?